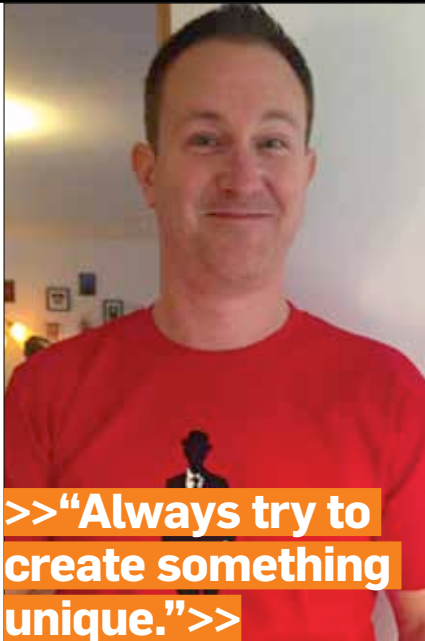




>>“Always try to create something unique.”>>

>>Magnus “Gordon” Gardebäck,
Co-founder, Simogo

One gets a sense of “less is more” in all of Simogo games. Can you tell us more?

Even though it's a less-is-more approach, I must say that all of our games have been challenging for me as a programmer. For example the physics in Bumpy Road that's made from scratch, to keep everything in sync to the music in Beat Sneak Bandit and such a simple thing as the ambitious scope of Year Walk. Both of us are also very picky when it comes to how things look and feel. We can spend huge amount of time polishing and tweaking until we're satisfied with the result. We use Unity for all our games which really helps me to focus on the gameplay related challenges but there's still stuff you need to deal with such as multiple resolutions, performance issues on older devices and asset pipeline to make production as smooth as possible.

Apart from the SDKs, which other developmental tools do you use to design and code your games?

As I mentioned, we use Unity but their built-in IDE for programming is not very impressive so I use Visual Studio instead since it's the best one out there. All code is written in C# and the code completion in VS really speeds up the development. I'm using a Mac Mini with both Mac OS and a virtual instance of Windows via Parallels. This setup works really well and I've been using it since we started development of DEVICE 6. In the past, we only worked on Windows machines and a Macbook laptop when compiling to device. With the current

setup, it's much faster since I can compile to device on the same machine and still have the advantages of Visual Studio. For content creation Simon uses Photoshop, Maya and some ancient software called MadTracker that is his favourite for making music.

Unity's the engine powering all Simogo games. What's so special about it?

It's a bit tricky to get started especially when you make 2D games but when you figure it out you can really make wonders on a short period of time. If nothing else, our track record is living proof of that. What we love the most about Unity is the non-existing compile time when editing code but that also goes for content. You can iterate without having to think about loosing any time. Also the fact that we have the option to publish our games to multiple platforms without having to port a large codebase was important to us. Additionally the Unity community and forums are a great resource of knowledge that's really helpful when you're new to this engine.

How did you start coding games and why do you still do it? What keeps you going?

I started to experiment with programming already on my Amiga 500 back in the early nineties but I didn't pursue that career until later on. My first job was as a programmer of video surveillance software. After 5 years in that role, I quit my job and got a university degree in computer science with game development in focus. When I was done

studying, I managed to get a job in the games industry at a studio that mainly developed downloadable console titles for XBLA and PSN. There I met Simon and then the rest is history. Making games is always interesting in that sense that it involves problem solving on a daily basis and you get to explore your creativity at the same time. And when making these smaller scope games that we do, you're always up for a new set of challenges and that keeps it fresh.

When you started Simogo, what are some of the rookie mistakes you committed?

We released our debut game in December and on the App Store that's a big no no. Such decisions as pricing, cross promotion and free campaigns to mention a few required a lot of discussion. And as a new developer you don't have anyone to talk to outside the team that can share experiences and provide tips of how to do things.

Any advice for indie game devs?

Always try to create something unique – do not replicate proven success. Take shortcuts to reduce development time – everyone does not have to implement their own game engine. And last but not least – try to attend as many game developer conferences as you can. They do help.

“Gordon” is the co-founder of Simogo. He joined the games industry back in 2007 and has been a part of several productions released on XBLA and PSN prior to starting Simogo in 2010 together with Simon Flessler.>

*coding matters



Java... Dead?

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<http://dgit.in/jvdtex>



The return of flow-based and functional programming

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